

Success cut short

While many of his contemporaries wrote three or more operas a year, the perfectionist Bellini rarely wrote more than one. His painstaking approach (he paid as much attention to the words as to the notes) at its best produced *La sonnambula* (1831), *Norma* (1831), and *I puritani* (1835), masterworks that secured Bellini's status as one of the highest-earning composers of the age.

In demand in both London and Paris, Bellini wrote *I puritani* for the French capital. He died of dysentery in the Paris suburbs in September 1835, nine months after the opera's premiere at the Théâtre Italien.

According to Bellini, "opera must make people weep, feel horrified, die through singing." The observation, which encapsulates his vision for the art form, is clear in its commitment to strong emotions, bold dramatic gestures, and the projection of tempestuous psychological states.